

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Science fiction, thriller

DIRECTOR

Ridley Scott

WRITERS

Hampton Fancher, David Webb Peoples (screenplay); Philip K. Dick (novel, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*)

STARS

Harrison Ford, Rutger Hauer, Sean Young, Daryl Hannah

BEFORE

1979 Ridley Scott's first foray into the future is the science-fiction horror *Alien*.

AFTER

2006 Philip K. Dick's novel *A Scanner Darkly*, about a future in the grip of an all-out war on drugs, is adapted as a partially animated thriller.

2012 Ridley Scott returns to science fiction with *Prometheus*, a prequel to the *Alien* franchise.

Near the end of *Blade Runner*, Roy Batty (Rutger Hauer), a fugitive at large in a near-future Los Angeles, delivers his last words to an ex-cop called Deckard (Harrison Ford). "I've seen things you people wouldn't believe," he says softly. "Attack ships on fire off the shoulder of Orion. I watched c-beams glitter in the dark near the Tannhäuser Gate. All those moments will be lost in time, like tears in rain. Time to die."

The speech strikes at a moral dilemma, because Roy Batty isn't human—he's a "replicant," an android bioengineered by industrial scientists at the all-powerful Tyrell Corporation. Replicants are supposed to be machines, yet Batty's desire to live and questioning nature prove that he has consciousness. For Deckard, a specially trained detective (blade runner) whose job it is to hunt down and liquidate rogue replicants, this realization is particularly relevant. If Batty can feel sorrow and longing, then how is he any different from his creators?

A hanging question

Science-fiction cinema is often memorable for its unforgettable visual images, from the robotic Maria sparking into life in Fritz

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As poignant as any sci-fi film I know... a film noir that bleeds over into tragedy.

David Thomson*Have You Seen...?*, 2008

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Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) to the mysterious black obelisk that bookends Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968). While *Blade Runner* also shimmers with visual poetry, it is Batty's lament, a few lines of semi-improvised dialogue, that truly cements the movie's place in movie history. The words articulate a question that hangs over Scott's enigmatic masterpiece: what does it mean to be human?

Blade Runner is set in 2019, a long way off to the audiences who first lined up to see it in 1982. At the time of its release, the movie presented a new kind of future, a weird fusion of familiar elements: corporate buildings the size and shape of Babylonian ziggurats; the

Minute by minute

